

Gaming Skillz!

Gamers are supposedly suffering from Game Transfer Phenomenon, where they try to do in real life what they do in games

Nimish Sawant, Anirudh Regidi and Mithun Mohandas

readersletters@tbindigit.com

Gaming is as important as any other application with the current crop of users. And to play a game, you need the right kind of card. With so many cards in the market, each with their own set of naming conventions and variation in specifications, picking the right card can be confusing. We at Digit understand this consumer dilemma. Keeping that in mind and, of course, the festive season of Diwali, when buying new items is a norm, we decided to pit over 40 of the best entry-level cards against each other.

Yes there are processors with integrated graphics, the latest being the AMD Llano APU which can play games upto 1680x1050 pixel in resolution. But for a great gaming experience, you do need a discrete graphics card.

Also, not everyone wants cards only for gaming. HTPCs are the new rage and with the proliferation of HDTVs in India, many readers want to set up an HTPC rig for which they'll need a card that will flawlessly play back HD content and even Blu-ray 3D content for 3D HDTV owners.

We kept the upper limit at ₹15,000 which we feel is the maximum a mainstream gamer would be willing to spend.

From ₹12K to ₹15K

This is the uppermost price bracket for this comparison test. Great performance is a given here but this category is where manufacturers try to entice the buyers with interesting accessories. Also many of the cards in this category were factory overclocked, thus giving the buyers more bang for the buck.

Here, the NVIDIA cards outnumbered the AMD cards 5:2. The surprise inclusion was HIS HD 6950 which was the only HD 69xx series card in the entire test. As for

NVIDIA, there were three GTX 560 and two GTX 560 Ti.

Apart from the obviously impressive pricing of HIS's Cayman Pro GPU, the other card that stood out was the EVGA GTX 560 Ti which had a special *Crysis 2* packaging on one side. The accessories will make any *Crysis* fanboy drool. Not only does it come bundled with a *Crysis 2 Limited Edition* disc, but also a *Crysis 2* T-shirt and a huge *Crysis 2* poster. The card itself looks wonderful with a sturdy black plastic body.

MSI N560GTX and R6870 Hawk had the stock settings, whereas Asus GTX 560 was overclocked to 925 MHz (stock: 810 MHz), ZOTAC GTX 560 Ti AMP Edition was overclocked to a whopping 950 MHz (Stock: 822MHz) and finally EVGA GTX 560 Ti was overclocked to 900 MHz (stock: 822 MHz). MSI R6870 sports the Twin Frozr III branding which means it will run quieter and cooler, thanks to the sturdy heatsink and the metal chassis for housing the fans. This was the best looking card amongst the others in this segment. Asus GTX 560 is another good-looking card with twin fans. ZOTAC cards have the same appealing race car-like design which helps in dissipating heat faster. The ZOTAC GTX

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EVGA GTX 560Ti: Crysis 2 Limited Edition

560 Ti comes with *Assassins Creed Brotherhood* gaming coupon.

Performance

When it came to pure numbers, the higher end HD 6950 was tamed by the factory overclocked GTX 560 Ti. There was a battle between just two cards here as the performance of the rest was sufficiently lower. ZOTAC GTX 560Ti AMP Edition and EVGA GTX 560Ti gave a neck-to-neck performance in this segment, with the former beating the latter in all tests. The credit

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